

The following code produced Table 1.

```
\begin{table}[!h]
%!h forces the table 'right here'
\centering
\begin{tabular}{|r|l|}
\hline
\textbf{FOSS Technology}&
\textbf{Description}\\
\hline
Apache&Web Server\\
\hline
Blender&3D-Modeller\\
\hline
LibreOffice&Office Suite\\
\hline
\end{tabular}
\caption{Example of a Table}
\end{table}
```

What would you do to remove the row and column separators? Try doing this yourself.

Math expressions

LATEX has rich support for mathematical formulas and technical typography. Let us try a couple of simple expressions to demonstrate the power of LATEX.

```
\begin{equation}
ax^2+bx+c=0
\end{equation}
are given by
\begin{equation}
\frac{-b \pm \sqrt{b^2-4ac}}{2a}
\end{equation}
```

Try this out and see what you get.

Note that the equation environment automatically numbers the equations and that you can literally type your way to typesetting your math expressions with a professional touch.

Colour-using packages

Colour is indispensable for persuasive documentation.

Let us explore how to use colour and also get a gentle introduction to using packages, 'color' being one of the less complicated ones.

The general syntax to include a package is:

```
\usepackage[options]{package-name}
```

To use the 'xcolor' package, you would give the following declaration in the preamble section of your .tex file:

```
\usepackage[usenames,dvipsnames,svgnames,table]{xcolor}
```

The options let you use predefined names such as 'Red' and 'Blue'. You can also define your own colours in the preamble section as follows:

```
\definecolor{myred}{rgb}{0.9,0,0}
\definecolor{mygreen}{rgb}{0,0.7,0}
\definecolor{mygray}{gray}{0.5}
```

Having declared the xcolor package and defined your own colours in the preamble section, let us try adding some colour to our text. Try this following code and see what you get.

```
{\color{Red}This is red text}
and this is text with a
\colorbox{mygray}{gray background}.
```

Inserting a TOC

A 'tableofcontents' command would insert a TOC right where it is issued. But remember that this is a two-pass process. Producing a TOC the first time requires you to run pdflatex twice on your .tex file so that the required .toc or .out files are produced. So, if your TOC is not getting produced or updated as you change your mark-up, you know what to do.

Including preformatted text

Producing preformatted text, something we have been doing a lot of for this article, can be done by just enclosing your preformatted text within the '\begin{verbatim}' and '\end{verbatim}' directives.

Will you TEX it?

If the power and convenience of LATEX has appealed to you, perhaps you will come back for the concluding part in which I will discuss, among other things, hyper-linking within and across documents, making your own custom commands, and best of all, creating a slick presentation. 

References

- [1] <http://www.stdot.org/winston/latex/> is a useful and handy cheat sheet.
- [2] <http://www.ctan.org> is the place for LATEX packages.
- [3] <http://www.ctan.org/pkg/short-english> offers a guide to LATEX. You can download the source code of this article from http://www.linuxforu.com/article_source_code/may13/latex.zip

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The author likes exploring the contribution of FOSS in improving the productivity of knowledge workers and also writing about it.